

FREE DOWNLOAD

The Senior *Wardrobe Guide.*

*How to shop, build, and style
outfits that photograph beautifully.*

How to build your outfit lineup.

Colors, fabrics & silhouettes that work on camera.

2026 trends worth wearing — and ones to skip.

Where to shop for every budget.

Accessories, shoes & the finishing details.

Austin-specific tips for Texas sessions.

27

WELCOME

Your Outfits Tell Your Story Before You Say a Word.

"What you wear is one of the biggest factors in how your images feel. The right outfit doesn't just look great — it makes you feel like yourself. And that's exactly what shows up on camera."

Wardrobe planning is the part of senior portrait prep that takes the most time — and causes the most stress. This guide removes both.

We've put everything we've learned shooting senior portraits in Austin into one place: what to buy, where to shop, how to build looks that photograph beautifully on camera — and feel completely like you.

Read it once. Then shop with intention. Your future self — the one looking at these images in ten years — will thank you.

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01

Build Your Lineup.

Most seniors stress about having 'enough' outfits. The real goal is having the right mix. Three to four looks — planned with intention — will give you more variety than six looks thrown together last minute.

LOOK 01

The Elevated Look

Dressy but still you. A flowy midi dress, a tailored set, a feminine blouse with wide-leg trousers. This is the look your parents will frame. Choose something that feels elevated — not costumed.

LOOK 02

The Real You

Your everyday style at its best. Jeans and a great top, your favorite jacket, something you actually reach for. This is often where the most genuine images happen — because you're most comfortable.

LOOK 03

The Meaningful One

Your sport, your culture, your instrument, your letter jacket. Something that says "this was who I was at 17." These images have the most emotional weight — ten years from now.

LOOK 04 — OPTIONAL

The Wild Card

Your prom dress. A bold pattern. Something editorial. A look you'd never normally wear but always wanted to. Use this slot to take a creative risk.

BUILDING EACH LOOK

+ Start with one hero piece.

Every look has a starting point — the dress, the jeans, the statement top. Build everything else around it. Don't start with accessories and work backward.

+ Add a completer piece.

Top + bottom + one piece that pulls it together. A jacket, an open cardigan, a belt, a vest. This layer gives you variety mid-session without a full outfit change.

+ Make sure it moves.

You will walk, sit on the ground, turn, laugh, crouch. If it restricts movement or needs constant adjusting — leave it home.

+ Try everything on — one week before.

Not the morning of. Wearing it in your living room tells you exactly how it feels, what needs steaming, and whether it actually works.

+ Send us photos before your session.

We will tell you honestly what works on camera and what might be a problem. A five-minute check saves you from bringing something that won't photograph well.

+ Shoes matter more than you think.

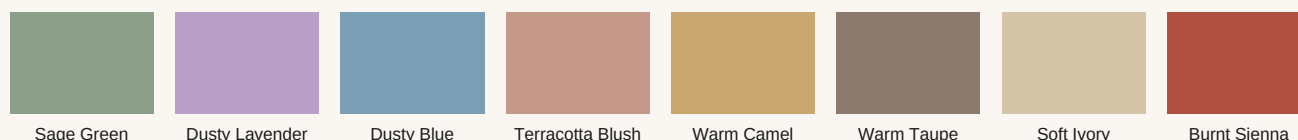
They show up in shots. Bring options. Make sure every pair is walkable — we move a lot on location.

02

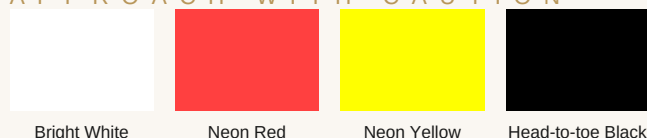
Colors & Fabrics.

Color is the single biggest wardrobe decision you'll make. The wrong shade washes you out or fights with your surroundings. The right one makes you glow — even in a simple outfit.

2026 COLORS THAT PHOTOGRAPH BEAUTIFULLY IN NATURAL LIGHT



APPROACH WITH CAUTION



← These compete with your face, blow out in sun, or swallow outfit detail on camera.

NOTE ON BLACK & WHITE

Black works as an accent or second piece — not as a full outfit.

White works beautifully paired with jeans or color, but goes stark alone in bright Austin sun.

FABRICS

+ Linen & cotton.

Breathable, textured, natural — essential for Austin heat. Wrinkles slightly but photographs with beautiful depth. Press the night before.

+ Chiffon & flowy fabrics.

Creates natural movement on camera. Flowy skirts and dresses photograph with life and dimension — especially in any breeze.

+ Denim.

Always works. The texture reads beautifully on camera and never goes out of style. Dark wash for elevated looks, light wash for casual.

+ Knit & sweater textures.

Cable-knit, ribbed, chunky textures add dimension and warmth. Great for fall sessions. Choose fitted over oversized for better silhouette.

+ Lace & embroidery.

Adds elegance and photographs with beautiful detail. Works especially well for one elevated look. Keep the rest of the outfit simple.

+ Velvet & satin.

Rich texture that reads luxurious on camera. Best in muted tones — jewel tones work, neons do not. Reserve for one statement piece.

+ Avoid: sheer without lining.

What you can barely see in the mirror shows clearly on camera. If a fabric is sheer, make sure it's fully lined or layered with something underneath.

+ Avoid: stiff or structured fabrics.

Anything that holds its shape rigidly limits your movement and creates stiff-looking poses. You want to move freely throughout the session.

03

2026 Trends on Camera.

Trends move fast. Some photograph beautifully — some look dated before the session ends. Here's what's working right now, and what to skip.

WORTH WEARING RIGHT NOW

+ **Retro silhouettes.**

High-waisted everything, A-line skirts, 70s boho dresses, 90s-inspired fits. Vintage and thrift-store finds photograph with a timeless quality that won't feel dated.

+ **Statement blazers.**

Oversized or fitted — a blazer instantly elevates any outfit and gives you a layer option. Neutral tones, plaids, and jewel tones all work beautifully.

+ **Flowy maxi dresses.**

The move they create on camera is genuinely difficult to replicate with any other piece. A good maxi dress does half the posing work for you.

+ **Coordinated sets.**

Two-piece sets — matching top and skirt or trouser — read polished and intentional on camera without requiring a lot of outfit planning.

+ **Jewel tones.**

Deep emerald, sapphire blue, rich burgundy, plum. They photograph with incredible depth in natural light and hold up beautifully against Austin's outdoor backdrops.

+ **Texture mixing.**

Denim jacket over a flowy dress, knit vest over a button-down. Mixing textures in one outfit creates visual richness that photographs far better than single-fabric looks.

SKIP FOR SESSION DAY

+ **Logo-heavy streetwear.**

Large brand logos and graphic tees pull attention away from your face immediately. If you love streetwear, choose the clean version — the same silhouette without the graphic.

+ **Overly trendy micro-trends.**

The look that's everywhere on TikTok right now may feel dated in two years. For at least one look, choose something that will feel timeless to your future self.

+ **Matching sets in overly bright colors.**

Coordinated sets work — but in neon or very bright tones they overwhelm the image. Stick to muted versions of trending colors.

+ **Head-to-toe one color in bright tones.**

Monochromatic works beautifully in neutrals and muted tones. In bright colors — all-red, all-yellow — it reads flat and can cause color cast on your face.

+ **Fast fashion that doesn't fit.**

Trend-driven pieces that don't fit properly photograph worse than a well-fitted basic. Always prioritize fit over trend.

The best senior portraits mix one timeless look with one or two trend-forward looks. The timeless one is what gets framed. The trend-forward ones are what get posted. Plan for both.

04

The Shopping Guide.

You don't need to buy everything new. But knowing where to look — for every budget and every style — saves hours. Here's where to shop, and what to look for in each place.

BUDGET-SMART (\$20–\$80)

Zara — trend-forward, well-cut, photographs clean. H&M — solid basics and seasonal dresses at low cost. ASOS — enormous range; filter by color and silhouette. Target (A New Day / Universal Thread) — linen, denim, basics that hold up on camera. Amazon Fashion — search by color + fabric type; read reviews carefully.

MID-RANGE (\$80–\$200)

Madewell — denim, linen, classics. Fits well and photographs with quality. Free People — boho dresses, flowy pieces, texture. Perfect for outdoor Austin sessions. Anthropologie — elevated, feminine, unique pieces that feel editorial on camera. Revolve — trend-forward, flattering silhouettes, great for a statement look. Nordstrom — reliable fit, good return policy if something doesn't work.

THRIFT & VINTAGE (any budget)

Buffalo Exchange Austin — curated secondhand, great for unique statement pieces. ThredUp / Poshmark — online thrift; search specific colors and silhouettes. Vintage stores on South Congress — unexpected finds that photograph with character. Your own closet — the piece you already love and feel incredible in.

FOR FORMAL LOOKS

Rent the Runway — designer dresses for a fraction of the cost. Excellent for one elevated look. BHLDN (Anthropologie bridal) — romantic, editorial dresses that photograph beautifully. Your own prom dress — if you love it, bring it. A great dress deserves more than one night. Nordstrom formal — reliable fit and style, wide range of price points.

SMART SHOPPING TIPS

+ Shop early — 3 to 4 weeks before your session.

You need time to return things that don't work, order replacements, and steam or tailor what you keep. Last-minute shopping leads to last-minute panic.

+ Send photos to us before you buy.

If you're unsure, send a photo of the piece — or you wearing it — before you commit. We'll give you an honest answer based on your location, lighting, and session vibe.

+ Buy to return — strategically.

Order several options in your color palette. Try them all on at home in your actual lighting. Keep what works, return the rest. This is how stylists shop.

+

05

Accessories & Shoes.

The right accessories complete a look. The wrong ones compete with your face. The rule is simple: every accessory should serve the outfit, not distract from it.

JEWELRY

- + **Dainty and layered works beautifully.**
Thin gold or silver chains, small hoops, delicate rings — they add to your look without competing with it. Layering two or three fine pieces creates visual interest.
- + **Statement pieces: one at a time.**
A bold necklace, an oversized earring, a chunky cuff — great for one look. But one statement per outfit. Not all three at once.
- + **Match metal to your skin tone.**
Gold reads warmer and photographs well with olive and deeper skin tones. Silver and platinum read cooler and work beautifully with fair and cool undertones. Rose gold is flattering across the board.
- + **Leave the sentimental jewelry at home.**
Not because it doesn't matter — because outdoor sessions involve movement, grass, sitting on the ground, and Texas wind. Don't risk a piece you can't replace.

BAGS, HATS & PROPS

- + **Hats — yes.**
A wide-brim hat, a baseball cap, a beret — hats add personality and create great variety within a single outfit. Bring one if it's genuinely part of your style.
- + **Sunglasses — yes, one pair.**
Vintage frames, bold shapes, classic aviators — they add a casual editorial quality. Use for one or two shots within a look, not for every frame.
- + **Small bags and clutches.**
A crossbody, a wicker bag, a mini clutch — they give your hands something to do and add a styled, editorial quality to the images.
- + **Meaningful props.**
Your instrument. Your sport equipment. Books you love. Items that tell your story without needing a caption. These create your most personal images.

SHOES — MORE IMPORTANT THAN MOST PEOPLE THINK

- + **They show up in shots.**
Shoes are in more frames than you realize — especially for sitting, standing, and full-length poses. Every pair you bring should be intentional.
- + **Walkability is non-negotiable.**
We move constantly on location — across fields, down sidewalks, through parks. If you can't walk comfortably in them, leave them home.
- + **For heels: chunky or wedge over stiletto.**
Stilettos sink into grass and make walking on location genuinely difficult. Chunky heels and wedges give you the elevation with actual stability.
- + **Bring a walkable pair for in-between.**
Sandals, white sneakers, or slides to wear between locations or outfit changes. Saves your feet and your shoes.

06

Austin-Specific Tips.

Austin is a different beast. The heat is real, the light is specific, and the season matters more here than almost anywhere else. Here's what to know before you shop.

THE HEAT — PLAN FOR IT

+ Breathable fabrics are not optional.

Linen, cotton, and chiffon are your best friends. Synthetic fabrics — polyester, nylon — trap heat and cause visible shine and discomfort on camera. If you're shooting in summer, build your entire wardrobe around breathable materials.

+ Blotting papers and setting powder in your bag — always.

Texas heat creates shine fast. Matte or satin foundation plus translucent setting powder keeps you camera-ready between looks. Bring blotting papers for touch-ups. This is not optional for summer sessions.

+ Layering strategy: light base, removable layer.

A tank or fitted layer underneath gives you a complete look when you remove the jacket or flannel — essentially two looks for one outfit change.

+ Dark colors absorb heat.

Deep jewel tones and black fabrics are beautiful on camera but get hot fast outdoors. If you love a dark piece, plan to wear it earlier in the session before the heat builds.

SEASONAL WARDROBE — AUSTIN

SPRING (Mar–May)

Light flowy dresses, soft pastels, linen sets. Wildflower season — a breezy dress in a natural setting is peak Austin magic.

SUMMER (Jun–Aug)

Breathable fabrics only. Lighter colors, minimal layers. Schedule sessions at golden hour — 7–8pm — when heat is bearable and light is extraordinary.

FALL (Sep–Nov)

The best season. Add texture — chunky knits, boots, jackets. Jewel tones and warm neutrals against fall color are stunning. Most popular season for a reason.

WINTER (Dec–Feb)

Austin winters are mild — perfect for layers without overheating. Cozy knits, leather jackets, boots. Crisp cool light makes colors pop more than any other season.

LOCATION MATTERS FOR WARDROBE

Urban downtown sessions: structured, editorial, bold color works. Natural locations (Barton Creek, Blunn Creek, parks): flowy, earthy tones, texture. Mixed sessions: build one look per environment and let us plan the flow.

07

The Night Before.

The more decisions you make the night before, the more present you can be on the day. Run through this list 24 hours before your session.

OUTFITS

- ☐ All outfits tried on and confirmed
- ☐ Everything steamed or pressed and hanging
- ☐ All accessories laid out with each look
- ☐ Shoes matched to each outfit and cleaned
- ☐ A fourth option set aside just in case
- ☐ Photos sent to us if any final questions

THE BAG

- ☐ Blotting papers packed
- ☐ Setting powder and touch-up makeup in a small bag
- ☐ A small brush and travel hairspray
- ☐ Bobby pins (wind is real)
- ☐ Water bottle and a light snack
- ☐ Your phone — and your phone charger

LOGISTICS

- ☐ Session time and location confirmed
- ☐ Parking location researched
- ☐ Driving route checked
- ☐ Plan to arrive 10 minutes early
- ☐ Someone whose energy you love — invited

THE MORNING OF

- ☐ Eat a real meal — not a granola bar
- ☐ Apply makeup in natural light
- ☐ Give yourself extra time to get ready
- ☐ Leave stress in the car
- ☐ Show up excited — everything else is handled

"The clients who walk away with images they love showed up knowing what they wanted, prepared enough to feel confident, and present enough to let the moments happen."

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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